

Some Advanced FFmpeg Tricks

FFmpeg is not just for video editing or video conversion. It's a versatile toolkit that has a world of creativity waiting at your fingertips. Try out some of its advanced tricks.



Image Source: <https://www.freepik.com>

Like *ffmpeg*, *ffplay* displays a huge banner and generates numerous text messages on the console. You can hide them using some switches:

```
ffplay -hide_banner -nodisp -autoexit \
Nightfall-Stone-Ship.mp3
```

Even with this arrangement, *ffplay* is not entirely quiet because it also writes to *standard error*. For a clean console, try:

```
ffplay -loglevel quiet \
Nightfall-Stone-Ship.mp3
```

FFmpeg integration with Caja file manager

Instead of GNOME 3, I use the user-friendly and customisable Mate desktop. The Mate project has forked the Nautilus file manager (from GNOME 2) and created a replacement called Caja. In Caja, I use *Caja Action Configurations* to create my custom menus for various multimedia file types. These custom menus make it easy to perform FFmpeg-related tasks on multimedia files.

Generating waveforms of audio streams

FFmpeg can create a variety of real-time graphics after analysing the waveforms of audio streams. To use the *showwavespic* filter, follow this script:

```
sInputFileName="$*"
sOutputFileName="$${sInputFileName%.*}.
```

Did you know that FFmpeg also includes a media player? Did you know that it can apply FFmpeg filters and play the output in real-time?

Early this year, my FFmpeg book was published by Apress. Interestingly, I continue to discover new FFmpeg tips and tricks every month. Here are some new ways with which I now use FFmpeg to automate my multimedia tasks.

FFplay

FFmpeg is a massive project. It is not just one executable. The FFmpeg project provides several executables for end users and several libraries for software developers. *ffmpeg*, *ffplay*, and *ffprobe* are the most popular programs for end users. Some other tools such as *ffescape* and *ffeval* appear to be available only for Windows users.

ffplay is a barebones media player.

It does not have any main menu or context menu. Users must employ certain keys and mouse actions to control playback.

Action	Function
SPACE bar	Play or pause playback
LEFT and RIGHT	Fast-forward or re-wind by 10 seconds
UP and DOWN	Fast-forward or rewind by 1 minute
Double-click	Toggle between windowed and full screen view
Right-click	Move forward or backward using an invisible playback slider